

# GASTROENTERITIS (STOMACH FLU)

## TIPS TO HELP YOU FEEL BETTER



Gastroenteritis is an infection of the stomach and intestines. It is usually caused by a virus and gets better on its own in a few days. The most important thing is to stay hydrated and rest.



### STAY HYDRATED – MOST IMPORTANT!

- Diarrhea and vomiting can cause your body to lose fluid and electrolytes.
- Sip small amounts of fluid often.
- Oral rehydration solutions (ORS) like Pedialyte® are best.
- Water, clear broth, and ice chips also help.
- Avoid sugary drinks, alcohol, caffeine, and very greasy foods.



### GET PLENTY OF REST

- Rest helps your body heal.
- It's normal to feel tired while your body fights the infection.



### EAT GENTLY

- Eat small amounts as tolerated.
- Start with bland, easy-to-digest foods.
- Avoid spicy, fatty, or high-sugar foods until you feel better.



### PREVENT SPREAD

- Wash your hands often with soap and water.
- Especially after using the bathroom and before eating.
- Clean and disinfect commonly touched surfaces.
- Stay home from work or school until diarrhea and vomiting have stopped for at least 24 hours.



### MEDICATIONS

- Use acetaminophen (Tylenol®) for fever or pain.
- Do NOT use aspirin or ibuprofen (Advil®, Motrin®) unless directed by a provider.
- Anti-diarrheal medicines (like loperamide/Imodium®) are usually not recommended, especially for children. Ask a provider if you are unsure.

### WHAT TO EXPECT



Symptoms usually start suddenly and last 1–3 days, but can last up to 7 days.

#### Common symptoms:



Nausea or vomiting



Diarrhea



Stomach cramps



Fever



Fatigue



### WHEN TO SEEK CARE

Get medical help right away if you or your child has:

- Signs of dehydration (see below)
- Fever of 102°F (38.9°C) or higher
- Blood in vomit or stool, or black/tarry stools
- Severe or constant abdominal pain
- Unable to keep liquids down for more than 24 hours
- Symptoms that last more than 7 days
- Dizziness, confusion, or decreased urination
- Any other symptoms that worry you



Most people get better at home with rest, fluids, and time. If symptoms worsen or you are concerned, please seek care.

## FLUID GUIDE

### ORAL REHYDRATION SOLUTION (BEST)

Use products like Pedialyte®, Hydralyte®, or store brand ORS.

Give small sips often.



### GOOD CHOICES

Clear fluids that are gentle on the stomach:



Water



Clear broth



Ice chips or popsicles



Diluted juice  
(1 part juice to  
1 part water)



Herbal tea  
(no caffeine)

### AVOID

These can make symptoms worse:



Soda or sugary drinks



Juice (undiluted)



Alcohol



Caffeine



Very greasy,  
spicy, or fried  
foods



Dairy (if it  
makes symptoms  
worse)

### BLAND FOODS TO TRY (AS TOLERATED)

Once you can keep fluids down, try small amounts of these:



Bananas



Rice



Applesauce



Toast



Saltine crackers



Plain pasta

- Eat small amounts.
- Stop if symptoms worsen.
- Gradually return to your normal diet as you feel better.



We are here to help. If symptoms are severe or you are concerned at any time, please call or come back in. We hope you feel better soon!

### IF YOUR SYMPTOMS PERSIST OR WORSEN, PLEASE FOLLOW UP WITH YOUR PROVIDER.

This handout is for educational purposes only and is not a substitute for professional medical advice.

Always consult your healthcare provider with any questions or concerns.